

Net Neutrality for the Nth time

BEING OUTRIGHT PARANOID about most things under the sun makes one question and pass silent judgement on everything. While things haven't progressed to the level that'd require being restrained in a straight jacket, there are events happening around the world that are not helping, at all. When corporations come forward claiming to fight the good fight on behalf of the common man, you don't need to be even the least paranoid to realise that something's definitely fishy. Yep, it's time for another rant on net neutrality. The FCC is hell bent on axing net neutrality in the US and in a few weeks, Ajit Pai might just get his way. Wait, scratch that he will definitely get his way. Fortunately for us Indians, the Indian PM and IT Minister, both recently voiced their support for net neutrality, so we're in the green for now at least.

Back in the US, it's interesting to see how the major ISPs are formulating their strategy around this polarising issue. On the one hand they have a good number of senators in their pockets, as we can see many echoing the same opinions as the ISPs. On the other hand, they're going around claiming that they support net neutrality while their actions suggest otherwise. It's gotten so bad that when the FCC opened the net neutrality issue up to the general populace to voice their opinions, a lot of bots were used to post fake replies on the website in favour of the ISPs' stance. The Office of the Attorney General of New York found several hundreds of thousands of such comments which were posted by bots when the real folks complained that they never went to the FCC site in the first place. And when asked for logs to help sort the fake comment issue out, what did the FCC do? Deny them all logs, of course. How transparent and consumer friendly of them!

Aside from the fake representation, there's another issue that people are overlooking. The whole premise of net neutrality is based on ensuring that there is no discrimination against internet companies. What people focus on is that this means that there shouldn't be any slow lanes to cripple internet traffic for smaller companies, but what people miss out on is that there shouldn't be any fast lanes either. The problem is, fast lanes already exist. Heck, the internet is built that way. Companies such as Netflix, Akamai,

YouTube and all Google's services employ some sort of peering with regional ISPs to ensure that their customers get super fast services, regardless of the bandwidth that the customer is paying for. So under net neutrality, in its purest form, such fast lanes would be killed off. This would lead to slower response times across all these services, and should any of them be bandwidth heavy, then you'll need to upgrade to a higher internet plan. And given how networks function, that might not even do the trick since higher bandwidth does not ensure good response times.

There are three ways to look at this. Implementing net neutrality as defined currently will mean that these services will be hit in the short term. Internet companies will realise that they will have to invest in building new infrastructure across the regions they serve to ensure better service. Then the onus will be on consumers to opt for better internet plans to match their bandwidth needs.

The second way is to have a gradual shift, i.e. take a look at current net neutrality laws and propose an intermediate period for companies to transition towards a fair system. This way, we're giving Internet companies plenty of time to transition and that'll lead to more jobs wherever these companies set up new facilities. And then we can have proper net neutrality.

The third way is to rethink the net neutrality laws to ensure fast lanes are considered a special case and should be retained. I prefer the second approach over compromising on the principles of net neutrality permanently, because given their nature, corporations will find ways to screw the consumer over. So letting them get their foot in the door is something we should avoid at all costs. Which of these ways would you pick? Or do you have a solution of your own? You know how to reach me. [1](#)



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